Literature Review

Credits: www.le.ac.uk

What is a Literature Review?

- Review research in your chosen area to clarify conceptual issues and empirical context for your project
- Use literature review to learn about research design for your project – build on work of previous scholars
- Consider how your project will contribute to the literature in your chosen subject area
- Your opportunity to persuade your reader (and examiner) that your work is relevant and that it was worth doing!

Three stages at which a review of the literature is needed

1. An early review is needed to establish the context and rationale for your study and to confirm your choice of research focus/question;
2. As the study period gets longer, you need to make sure that you keep in touch with current, relevant research in your field, which is published during the period of your research;
3. As you prepare your final report or thesis, you need to relate your findings to the findings of others, and to identify their implications for theory, practice, and research.

Questions that your examiners ask: literature review can help you answer

- What research question(s) are you asking? Why?
- Has anything similar been done in this area before?
- What is already known/understood about this topic?

How to get started: ask yourself these questions

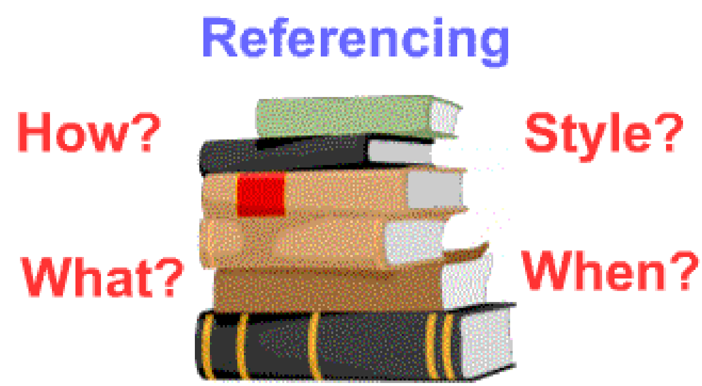
- What is the specific thesis, problem, or research question that my literature review helps to define?
- What type of literature review am I conducting?
- Am I looking at issues of theory? methodology? policy? quantitative research? qualitative research?
- What is the scope of my literature review? What types of publications am I using (e.g., journals, books, government documents, popular media, systems manuals)?
- What time period am I interested in? What geographical area? What social setting? What materials?

Structure of the Literature Review:

- There is not one ‘ideal’ structure for your literature review so talk to your supervisor about this
- Consider whether you wish to organize your literature review chronologically, thematically, by development of ideas (or a combination of these)
- Make sure that you always explain your structure for your reader and have a clear narrative

Referencing

- Provide full details of all sources cited in the literature review and thesis/ project report.
- Should include published books or articles, book chapters, technical reports, web sources, etc.
- Consult your department guidelines for more on referencing style
- Make sure you understand the university regulations on plagiarism



Sources for literature review

- Identify key primary sources (e.g. books, journal articles, conference papers) relevant to your topic early on

- Use relevant search terms on online sources (e.g. Springer, Elsevier, IEEE Xplore, Google Scholar)

- Remember, there is no target for the number of references you include, but you need to show that you have covered the literature that is relevant to your project.

Writing Literature – Present

- **A review of current research work, or research work of immediate relevance to your study.**

  Example:

  - *Schulze [1] concludes that hydraulic rate has a significant effect on future performance.*

[1] Adrian Schulze, "Impact of hydraulic rate", IEEE Stress, 2002, pages 1-6.

Writing Literature– Past

- **Report the contents, findings or conclusions of past research**

  Examples:

  - *Haberfield (1998) showed that the velocity of many enzyme reactions was slowed down if the end product had an increased paramagnetism.*
  - *Allington (1999) found that the temperatures varied significantly over time.*

Writing Literature– Present perfect

- **In citations where the focus is on the research area of several authors**

  Examples:

  – *Several studies* ***have provided*** *support for the suggestion that the amount of phonological recoding that is carried out depends on orthographic depth (Frost, 1994; Smart et al, 1997; Katz & Feldman, 2001, 2002).*

  – *Joint roughness has been characterized by a number of authors (Renger, 1990; Feker & Rengers, 1997; Wu & Ali, 2000).*

- **To generalize about the extent of the previous research**

  Examples:

  – *Many studies have been conducted in this field.*

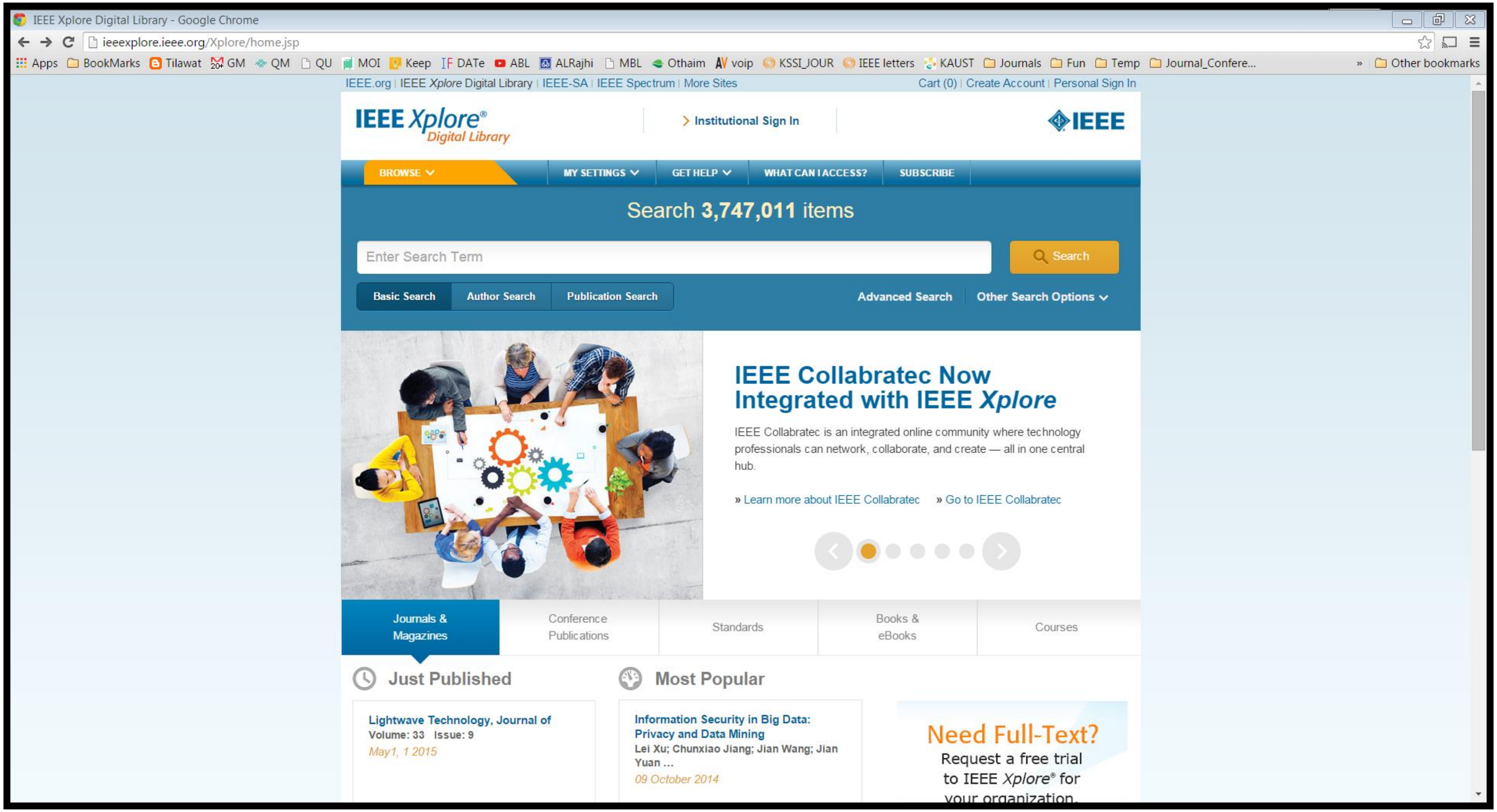
  – *Few researchers have examined this technique.*

  – *There has been extensive research into.........*

Searching For Literature: Source of literature review

- **Springer**
- **Elsevier**
- **IEEE Xplore**
- **ACM**
- Google Scholar
- Many other sources
- ….

IEEE Xplore



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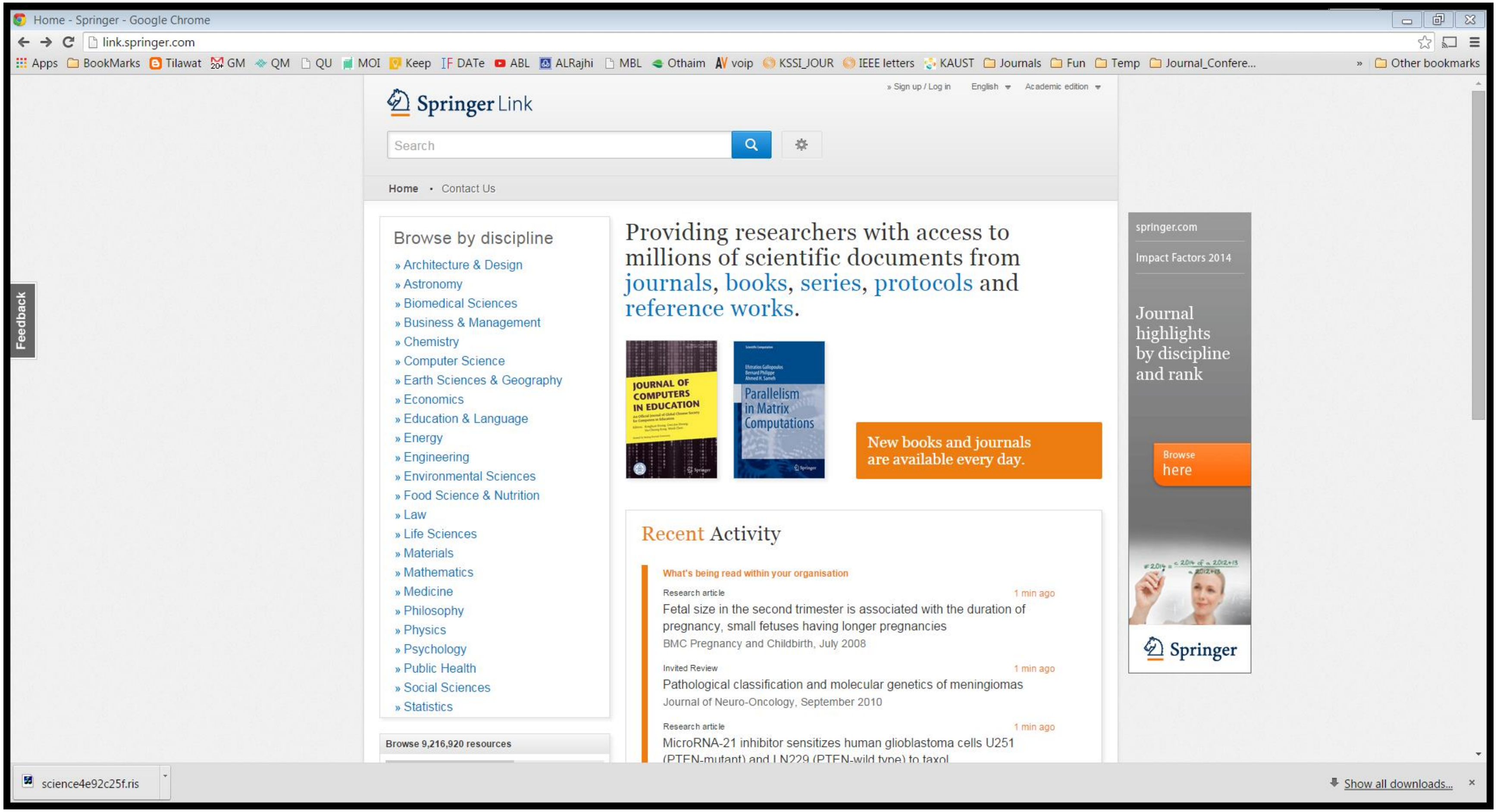
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BMC Pregnancy and Childbirth, July 2008
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Journal of Neuro-Oncology, September 2010
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Evaluation Criteria

- **Evaluation Criteria**

[the criteria could be different slightly from topic to another]

1. **References**:
    a. Current.
    b. Cover the related topic/s adequately.
    c. Cover all the previous work.
    d. Based on good reputation publishers.
    e. Based on heavy and well evaluated /reviewed work (etc.: journals more than conferences).

Evaluation Criteria

2. **Literature review**:
    a. **Background**
        i. Relative.
        ii. Current
        iii. Comprehensive/complete.
        iv. Precise and concise
        v. Structured in rational sequence.
    b. **Related works**
        i. Current.
        ii. Cover the related point of research adequately.
        iii. Comprehensive/complete.
        iv. Include precise and concise briefing.
        v. Introduced in a logical structure and sequence (chronologically, thematically, by development of ideas (or a combination of these)).
        vi. Clearly discuss and compare different studies methodologies/frameworks/systems/models/techniques.
        vii. Has a final critical analysis.